

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

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2 Thessalonians 1:1-2

Paul follows ancient letter writing customs, but instead of the normal greeting (Greek *chairein*) he blesses them with grace (Greek *charis*) and peace.

2 Thessalonians 1:2

God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ are coequal as the source of grace and peace. The Thessalonians' hope was bound to God's grace ([2:16](#)), and even in persecution they could experience God-given peace ([3:16](#)).

2 Thessalonians 1:3

Dear brothers and sisters: Greek *adelphoi*, a generic term that refers to members of the same family, both male and female. • thank God: Paul begins with thanksgiving for the Thessalonians' faith, love, and "endurance" ([1:4](#)). These fundamental Christian virtues (see [1 Cor 13:13](#); [Col 1:4-5](#); [Heb 10:21-24](#); [1 Pet 2:1-22](#)) were maturing in the church despite the persecution they endured ([2 Thes 1:5](#)).

2 Thessalonians 1:3-10

After thanking God for the Thessalonian church ([1:3-4](#)), Paul writes about persecution ([1:4](#)), which had intensified since his first letter ([1 Thes 1:6](#); [2:14](#); [3:3-4](#)). God will relieve their suffering ([2 Thes 1:5-10](#)) and judge their persecutors.

2 Thessalonians 1:4

Paul's boasting to other churches about the Thessalonians' endurance and faithfulness would stimulate the church's resolve to endure and remain faithful in the face of great hostility ([1 Thes 2:14](#); [3:3-4](#)).

2 Thessalonians 1:5

Those called by God to enter his Kingdom will suffer for it ([Acts 14:22](#); [1 Thes 2:12](#)).

2 Thessalonians 1:7

rest: Relief from suffering. • Elsewhere, Paul speaks of Christ's "coming" ([2:1](#); [1 Thes 2:19](#); [3:13](#); [4:15](#); [5:23](#)); here, he speaks of the event as the "appearing" or "unveiling" of the Lord Jesus, who cannot currently be seen physically (cp. [1 Pet 1:7-8](#); [4:13](#)).

2 Thessalonians 1:9

They will be punished for rejecting the message about Christ ([1:8](#)). • Eternal destruction (see [1 Thes 5:3](#); [1 Tim 6:9](#)) is irrevocable. • Separated from the Lord refers to the source of the judgment to come ([Isa 2:10](#), [19](#), [21](#)).

2 Thessalonians 1:10

that day: The day of the Lord ([2:2](#); [1 Thes 5:2-4](#); see "The Day of the Lord" Theme Note).

2 Thessalonians 1:11

enable you to live a life worthy of his call: Paul had previously reminded the Thessalonians that God called them to conduct themselves "in a way that God would consider worthy" ([1 Thes 2:12](#); see also [Eph 4:1](#); [Phil 1:27](#); [Col 1:10](#)). • Paul prayed that God would give the Thessalonian Christians power to live and work in a manner that would please God.

2 Thessalonians 1:11-12

Paul assures the Thessalonian believers of God's promised justice, both for them and their persecutors ([1:5-10](#)). Because future deliverance means carrying out present responsibilities, Paul prays that they will be found worthy at Christ's return.

2 Thessalonians 1:12

Though the name of our Lord Jesus was rejected by the Thessalonians' persecutors ([1:8](#)), Jesus will ultimately be glorified because of the lives of the believers. Further, they will be honored along with him ([2:14](#); [1 Thes 2:12](#); cp. [Rom 8:17-18](#); [Col 3:4](#)). Cp. [Isa 66:5](#).

2 Thessalonians 2:1

At the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ ([1:7-10](#); [1 Thes 2:19](#); [3:13](#); [4:15-5:2](#); [5:23](#)), all of his people will be gathered to meet him. This will occur at the resurrection and rapture of the church ([1 Thes 4:13-18](#)).

2 Thessalonians 2:1-12

False teaching about the day of the Lord had disturbed the Thessalonian church ([2:1-2](#)). Paul reminds them ([2:5](#)) that two events will precede that day: a great apostasy and the unveiling of the man of lawlessness ([2:3-12](#)). Christ will destroy this man when he returns ([2:3](#), [8](#)), and those who have been deceived will also be judged ([2:9-12](#)).

2 Thessalonians 2:2

The Thessalonian Christians previously asked Paul when the day of the Lord would come ([1 Thes 5:1-11](#)). Now a false teaching that this day had already begun (cp. [2 Tim 2:18](#)) was causing them to waver in faith and become frightened. • a spiritual vision, a revelation, or a letter: The source of the teaching might have been a false prophecy (cp. [1 Jn 4:1-2](#)), an erroneous sermon, or a letter falsely attributed to Paul.

2 Thessalonians 2:3

Two events will precede that day of the Lord ([2:2](#)). • Both Jewish and Christian theology predicted a great rebellion against God before the end ([Matt 24:11-14](#); [1 Tim 4:1](#)). • The man of lawlessness is without or against law; his character is defined by sin. • the one who brings destruction (or *the one destined for destruction*): The emphasis is on the

lawless man's own destruction ([2 Thes 2:8](#)) rather than on the destruction he brings.

2 Thessalonians 2:4

exalt himself: Like other Roman cities, Thessalonica constructed temples for the worship of the emperor. This cult was the prototype of the worship described here. • He will even sit in the temple of God: The profaning of the Temple in Jerusalem by Antiochus Epiphanes in 167 BC (see [Dan 9:27](#); [11:31](#); [12:11](#)) may have prefigured the event predicted here ([Matt 24:15](#); [Mark 13:14](#)). Or it may refer to the attempt of the emperor Caligula, called "the new god manifest," to erect his own image in the Temple in AD 40. Alternatively, the temple may be an imperial temple (*of God* could be *of the god*) erected in honor of the lawless man and not necessarily a rebuilt temple in Jerusalem. • claiming that he himself is God ([Ezek 28:2-10](#)): The ascription of divine titles to the emperor was common in the first century.

2 Thessalonians 2:6

what is holding him back: This has been variously identified as God, the Holy Spirit, the church, the gospel, Paul, the emperor, the Roman Empire, or the government. Alternatively, the term may refer to something or someone who comes before the man of lawlessness, an agent of the lawlessness active at that time ([2:7-8](#)); in Greek literature, this expression could describe demonic possession. This figure would prepare the way for the man of lawlessness when his time comes ([2:3](#), [8](#)).

2 Thessalonians 2:7

The power of the coming man of lawlessness ([2:3-6](#)) is already at work secretly, like the antichrists of [1 Jn 2:18](#). • secretly (Greek *mustērion*): A descriptor commonly used of rituals in the mystery religions (see [2 Thes 2:6](#)). • at work: This connotes supernatural intervention, whether divine ([1 Thes 2:13](#)) or, as here, evil ([2 Thes 2:9](#); [Eph 2:2](#)). • The one who is holding it back could refer to one who is in opposition to the man of lawlessness; to one who is possessed; or to Satan, the one who possesses ([2 Thes 2:9](#); see study note on 2:6).

2 Thessalonians 2:8

Paul announces the doom of the man of lawlessness (cp. [2:3](#)). Although this figure claims to be divine, places his cult above all other worship ([2:4](#)), and receives power from Satan ([2:9](#)), the Lord Jesus will violently and utterly destroy him ([Isa 11:4](#)). • splendor: A reference to Christ's epiphany ([1 Tim 6:14](#); [2 Tim 1:10](#); [4:1](#), [8](#); [Titus 2:13](#)), an alternative description of Christ's coming ([2 Thes 2:1](#); [1 Thes 2:19](#); [3:13](#); [4:15](#); [5:23](#)) or unveiling ([2 Thes 1:7](#)). In ancient literature, an *epiphany* was the appearance of a deity or a demonstration of divine power that evoked worship.

2 Thessalonians 2:9

Christ will appear in royal and divine power. It is his *parousia*, meaning "presence" or "arrival" or "coming" ([2:1](#), [8](#); [1 Thessalonians 2:19](#); [3:13](#); [4:15](#); [5:23](#)). The coming (*parousia*) of the lawless one will also include a royal entrance.

2 Thessalonians 2:11

As seen elsewhere in Scripture ([Exod 9:12](#); [2 Chr 18:22](#)), God sometimes hands people over to the power of the sin or deception they have desired in place of the truth ([Rom 1:24](#), [26](#), [28](#); [11:8](#)).

2 Thessalonians 2:12

They will be condemned (see [1:6-9](#)) by God's judicial verdict for not believing the truth ([2:10](#)), instead believing the lie of the man of lawlessness ([2:9-10](#)).

2 Thessalonians 2:14

He called you to salvation: God calls his chosen ones to himself ([1:11](#); [1 Thes 2:12](#); [4:7](#); [5:24](#)) through the preaching of the Good News. • Those who suffer because of their faith will ultimately share in the glory of our Lord Jesus Christ ([Rom 5:2](#); [8:17-18](#); [Col 1:27](#); [1 Thes 2:12](#)).

2 Thessalonians 2:15

Ever since the founding of the Thessalonian church, Paul had been concerned for the stability of their faith ([1 Thes 3:2](#), [5](#), [8](#); [4:1-2](#)) and their adherence to his teaching ([2 Thes 3:6](#); [1 Cor 11:2](#); [15:3](#); see [Jude 1:3](#)).

2 Thessalonians 2:16

Eternal comfort and . . . hope transcend both death and uncertainty about the immediate future.

2 Thessalonians 2:17

Paul's prayer echoes the purpose of Timothy's visit to the church—to strengthen and encourage the Thessalonian believers in their faith ([1 Thes 3:2](#)). • To comfort you does not merely mean to *console*, but to *exhort* or *encourage* them because of their fears and doubts ([2 Thes 2:1-12](#); [1 Thes 4:18](#); [5:11](#)).

2 Thessalonians 3:1

pray: The prayer that the gospel would spread rapidly recalls [Ps 147:15](#). Paul merges the image with reference to the games (see [1 Cor 9:24-26](#); [Gal 2:2](#)) in which a victor was honored.

2 Thessalonians 3:1-5

Before taking up the final topic of the letter ([3:6-15](#)), Paul requests prayer ([3:1-2](#)) and assures the Thessalonians of God's providence in troubles ([3:3-5](#)).

2 Thessalonians 3:2

Paul, too, suffered for the Good News ([2 Cor 6:5](#); [11:23-26](#); [1 Thes 2:2](#)). His prayer to be rescued echoes [Isa 25:4](#).

2 Thessalonians 3:3

The sufferings the Thessalonians faced were caused by the evil one (or by *evil*; see [2:9](#); cp. [1:4-6](#); [1 Thes 1:6](#); [2:14](#)).

2 Thessalonians 3:5

The prayer that God would lead (literally *make straight*) their hearts reflects an Old Testament expression ([1 Chr 29:18](#); [Prov 23:19](#)). Christians are expected to love as God loves and practice patient endurance as Christ endured.

2 Thessalonians 3:6

Paul's command is given by the authority of the Lord Jesus Christ ([1 Thes 4:2](#)). • Church members should shun Christians who live idle lives (see [2 Thes 3:7, 11-13](#); [1 Thes 5:14](#)). To stay away from the lazy would make a strong impression on them ([Matt 18:17](#); [Rom 16:17](#); [1 Cor 5:9-13](#)), promoting shame ([2 Thes 3:14](#)) and repentance, but stopping short of excommunication ([3:15](#)).

2 Thessalonians 3:6-15

In his previous letter, Paul had addressed the problem of lazy members of the church who refused to work ([1 Thes 4:11-12](#); [5:14](#)). Some had ignored his message and example, so he gives additional instruction for dealing with these members.

2 Thessalonians 3:7

Teaching by example was highly regarded in the ancient world. Paul himself provided an example by working for his own food ([3:8](#); [1 Thes 2:9](#)).

2 Thessalonians 3:8

without paying for it: Although Paul taught that workers in the Christian church could receive pay for their labor ([3:9](#); see [Matt 10:10](#); [1 Cor 9:7-14](#); [1 Tim 5:17-18](#)), he did not take advantage of that privilege ([1 Thes 2:9](#); [2 Thes 3:6-10](#)).

2 Thessalonians 3:9

Paul had distanced himself from others in the culture who were motivated by fame and money ([1 Thes 2:5](#)).

2 Thessalonians 3:10

Work is the appropriate way to gain a living (see [Gen 3:17-19](#); [Ps 128:2](#); [Prov 10:4](#)). Paul absolves the church of the responsibility of feeding other believers who refuse to work.

2 Thessalonians 3:12

Paul underscores the strength of the command by appealing to the authority of the Lord Jesus (as in [3:6](#); [1 Thes 4:1-2](#)). • settle down: i.e., lead a quiet life instead of being involved in meddlesome activities (see [1 Thes 4:11](#)).

2 Thessalonians 3:13

doing good: The Thessalonians were exhorted to reach out and help those in genuine need (see [Gal 6:9-10](#)), in contrast with those who are lazy and dependent ([2 Thes 3:7-8, 10](#)).

2 Thessalonians 3:14

Paul hoped that the disobedient Christians would be ashamed and repent (see study note on 3:6) in response to being shunned by the community.

2 Thessalonians 3:15

Don't think of them as enemies: In the ancient world, social relations with enemies were broken off and punitive action was initiated against them. Paul warns the Thessalonians that discipline against disobedient Christians ([3:14](#)) should not result in this kind of attack. Rather, the church should treat them as members of the family, with the hope that they would correct their conduct ([1 Thes 5:12, 14](#)).

2 Thessalonians 3:16

The final prayer echoes Jesus' blessing in [John 14:27](#) (cp. [Num 6:26](#)) and contrasts with the situation these believers faced in Thessalonica ([2 Thes 1:4-10](#); [1 Thes 2:14](#)). Paul was always

conscious of the Lord Jesus' presence with his people ([Rom 15:33](#); [Phil 4:9](#)).

2 Thessalonians 3:17

A secretary had written this letter for Paul ([Rom 16:22](#); [1 Pet 5:12](#)). Now Paul takes the pen to add a final greeting in his own hand (cp. [1 Cor 16:21](#); [Gal 6:11](#); [Col 4:18](#); [Phlm 1:19](#)). Because he suspected that a letter he had not written was circulating under his name ([2 Thes 2:2](#)), he emphasizes this authenticating procedure to prove this letter is from him.

2 Thessalonians 3:18

Ancient letters frequently ended with a wish for health or prosperity, but Paul's blessing is much grander: He calls on the Lord Jesus Christ to grant grace to the recipients (see [1 Thes 5:28](#)).